In the letter, Mistry accused Ratan of hurting his dignity. He said, ‘Apart from the invalidity and illegality of the business that was conducted, I have to say that the Board of Directors has not covered itself with glory. To “replace” your Chairman without so much as a word of explanation and without affording him an opportunity of defending himself in a summary manner must be unique in the annals of corporate history.’ Mistry also asserted that the financial problems of Tata Power, Tata Motors, Tata Steel, Tata Teleservices and IHCL were on account of Ratan’s faulty decisions. He further blamed Ratan for taking questionable calls on Tata Power’s Mundra project, the Nano, NTT Docomo and IHCL’s purchase of the Sea Rock property. He also alleged that corporate governance under his predecessor had touched a new low. In contrast, he claimed that he had done well in protecting the interests of the group.

The letter contained many ‘misstatements’, says Andrew Robb, chairman of Tata Steel Europe. Commenting on Mistry’s assertion that, ‘The European steel business faced potential impairments in excess of [US]$10 bn,’ he says that ‘Mistry had plucked it [the figures] from the air’. His version of the impairment was ‘completely untrue’, he continues, and adds that the letter should not have been sent as it was ‘extremely damaging’. Jacques Schraven, former chairman of the supervisory board of Tata Steel Nederland B.V. and independent director on the board of Tata Steel, was also equally critical of this assertion. He said that the allegation of the ‘[US]$10 bn impairment was not only wrong, it was unforgivable because, we should have done that already, and he should have done that himself, if that were true’.

Ratan had not expected Mistry to contest the right of the majority shareholder to remove him. Commenting on the attack on the conglomerate’s working and functioning, a visibly hurt Ratan says that it was not normal for a former chairman to adopt a ‘scorched earth’ policy and make efforts to ‘diminish the company, to disintegrate and dismember’ it.

The day after Mistry sent the letter, the NSE and the BSE wrote to the five companies—Tata Power, Tata Motors, Tata Steel, Tata Teleservices and IHCL—seeking their comments on the charges made by Mistry. The companies replied that their accounts were in order.

The following day, Tata Sons issued a rejoinder to the allegations, terming them ‘malicious’ and faulting Mistry for ‘casting aspersions on the Tata group’. It justified his replacement on the ground that the ‘tenure of the